

THE VALUE OF AN INDIVIDUAL

TEXT: Luke 15:1-7 “Now the tax collectors and “sinners” were all gathering around to hear him. But the Pharisees and the teachers of the law muttered, “This man welcomes sinners and eats with them.” Then Jesus told them this parable:

“Suppose one of you has a hundred sheep and loses one of them. Does he not leave the ninety-nine in the open country and go after the lost sheep until he finds it? And when he finds it, he joyfully puts it on his shoulders and goes home. Then he calls his friends and neighbors together and says, ‘Rejoice with me; I have found my lost sheep.’ I tell you that in the same way there will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent.”

INTRO: In our society everything is based on number; how much money a person has, how high or low the stock market is the gross sales of a company, the population of a city, and on and on I could go!

This group mentality has even found its way into the Church. We have judged ourselves on:

- How big or small the crowd is...
- How many our group has in it...
- How large our staff is...
- How many people came to the evangelistic crusade...
- How many joined the Church...
- How many were baptized...

- How big the budget is...
- How many total dollars were given to missions...

(Preachers and singers will not go to a church if it cannot seat enough people!)

The question must be asked, *is God at all interested in our facts and figures?* Is He interested in our numbers? Yes! *Several times in the Bible people were commanded by God to number various things!*

- The woman counted her coins...
- The fisherman counted his fish...
- The king counted his troops...
- The farmer counted his crop...
- The builder counted the cost...

God deemed numbers so important that He named a book in His Bible Numbers. While numbers are important to God and important in the Bible, at other times certain people were commanded not to count. David got in serious trouble with God for counting the people. (70,000 men died by the plague of the Lord)

While all of these things are important, our scripture text makes us aware that nothing is more important than an individual.

While God values an individual as His most valuable creation this world's system devalues the worth of an individual. The United States and Japan conducted a study to determine the value of an individual. This

study was based on the composition of the human body. The value of the human body:

- 65% oxygen...
- 18% carbon
- 10% hydrogen...
- 3% nitrogen...
- 1.5% calcium...
- 1% phosphorus...
- .05% magnesium...
- .035% potassium...
- .025% sulfur...
- .015% sodium
- .015% chlorine...
- .0004% iron...
- .00004% iodine...
- Fourteen to eighteen square feet of skin...

Total value? \$4.50 - \$5.00! Maybe this explains why abortion is so accepted. According to this worlds system an individual is not worth much but according to God there is nothing more valuable than a person!

As a Church we must reach a point where the importance of an individual is non-negotiable! We must guard against an “*easy come, easy go,*” attitude with regard to individuals. As a Pastor, I have seen a time when we had to subtract before we could multiply. In such cases I always find myself wondering if something else could have been done. (Back door revival)

Nowhere is the priority of the individual more vivid than in the life and teachings of Christ Himself!

I. SALVATION IS AN INDIVIDUAL EXPERIENCE...

2 Peter 3:9 ***"The Lord is not slow in keeping his promise, as some understand slowness. He is patient with you, not wanting anyone to perish, but everyone to come to repentance."*** Here Peter reveals that Jesus

and the Father are motivated to see the salvation of 20 billion people who have called planet Earth their home! That huge crowd does not even include those who are not yet born! **God deems individuals so important that He has set in motion a Divine plan which provides for every person who would ever enter the world both past, present, and future to be saved.**

Rev. 3:20 ***"Here I am! I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears my voice and opens the door, I will come in and eat with him, and he with me."***

While God desires salvation for every human being, the speed with which this will be accomplished will never exceed the rate of one individual at a time!
(North New Hope – 10 grown men)

The salvation of the individual drove the entire redemptive plan; nothing else has ever taken priority!
"Go into all the world and preach the Gospel to every creature." (Changing of the Guard – *"Orders Remain Unchanged!"*)

Salvation is never a group experience! Salvation is for the individual. (My mother singled me out. God singled me out in the spring of 1973)

If the whole world gets saved today, they will get saved one at a time!

II. THE INDIVIDUAL NATURE OF GOD'S PLAN...

The individual nature of God's plan overwhelmed the psalmist David. Psalm 8:3-4 ***"When I consider your heavens, the work of your fingers, the moon and the stars, which you have set in place, what is man that you are mindful of him, the son of man that you care for him?*** With His fingers He traced out courses for the Rivers, yet he is focused on some of the most pragmatic issues of our day.

A survey of the Old Testament reveals that God has always prioritizes the individual. This is true from:

- From Abraham to Amos
- From Deborah to Daniel
- From Enoch to Ezekiel
- From Hagar to Habakkuk
- From Hezekiah to Hosea
- From Hilkiah to Haggai
- From Isaac to Isaiah
- From Jacob to Jeremiah
- From Jehosophat to Jonah
- From Jochebed to Joel
- From Melchisedec to Malachi
- From Miriam to Micah

- From Noah to Nahum
- From Obed to Obadiah
- From Zidon to Zechariah
- From Zipporah to Zephaniah

Through the decades and the centuries of the Old Testament God's love singled out each individual and His love was conveyed to each person, then in the New Testament God sent Jesus to take his love for the individual to another level. The love of Jesus demonstrates the individual is more important than rivers, deserts, mountains, valleys etc....

Jesus' teaching communicates the centrality of the individual but his life and ministry made this truth even clearer:

- Zacchaeus...
- The Samaritan woman...
- Legion... (We are so group oriented that we focus more on how many devils were cast out then the fact that this man sat at the feet of Jesus clothed and in his right mind.)
- The thief on the cross...

While the value of an individual must be kept in focus, it is also true that there is strength in numbers; *"One can put a hundred to flight but two can put ten thousand to flight!"*

While two are stronger than one, one is enough for every challenge, if empowered by God!

- David and Goliath...

- Samson pulled down the house of the Philistines...
- Shammah defended a pea patch...
- A little boys lunch...

CONCLUSION:

Notice our text, [Luke 15:1-7](#) “*Now the tax collectors and “sinners” were all gathering around to hear him. But the Pharisees and the teachers of the law muttered, “This man welcomes sinners and eats with them.” Then Jesus told them this parable: “Suppose one of you has a hundred sheep and loses one of them. Does he not leave the ninety-nine in the open country and go after the lost sheep until he finds it? And when he finds it, he joyfully puts it on his shoulders and goes home. Then he says, ‘Rejoice with me; I have found my lost sheep.’ I tell you that in the same way there will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent.”*

Notice four very important things here:

- The shepherd who owns 100 sheep has lost one! (Probably not the first offense)
- The drastic measures to find one lone sheep! “*He leaves 99 in the open country and searches until he finds the one lost sheep!*” (Two legs & a piece of ear... Take it to the sale barn... Shear it whether needed or not... No sale barn or lamb chops...)
- The celebration! He puts it on his shoulders; he brings it home; he calls his friends and

neighbors together and invites them to participate in the homecoming celebration!)

- The most astounding thing about all of this is the words of Jesus in verse 7, ***"I tell you that in the same way there will be more rejoicing in heaven over one sinner who repents than over ninety-nine righteous persons who do not need to repent."***

Can anyone determine the value of an individual? As a church we need to refocus on the value of individuals!

(Offer challenge to each family to focus on one un-churched family over the summer months in an effort to bring them to Christ and His church.)

1st A/G Malvern, AR 10/4/98 AM
Juarez Mexico, 9/6/98 Staff Meeting
Juarez Mexico, 9/8/98 Bible School
Rolfes Chapel, Wynne, AR 10/19/98 Sectional Council
Harvestine A/G, Mayreesboro, AR 1/19/99 Fellowship Meeting
Channel 39 West Monroe, LA 9/30/99
CTAG Houston, TX 7/27/03 AM
Park fellowship, Estes Park, CO 8/7/05
CT Church, Houston & Pearland, TX 6/10/07

